Matt Damon's ship from 'The Odyssey' needs your help

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The lifesize wooden ship that took a beating during Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey is due for some much-deserved care, and its owners are looking for volunteers to help. The 50-oar Draken Harald Hårfagre is scheduled for routine maintenance, and volunteers are encouraged to apply online, provided they can get to Norway by April 2027. 'A project like Draken depends not only on a professional crew and sailing deckhands, but also on dedicated volunteers who help support the life of the ship,' reads its official website. Volunteering offers a hands-on way to contribute while learning about the vessel and the community that keeps the project moving, the website says.

Nolan's blockbuster adaptation of The Odyssey is a massive movie, and much of its scale comes from practical effects. Instead of relying on computer-generated imagery, the award-winning director used full-sized set pieces like an actual Trojan Horse. But one of the film's most prominent examples was not actually built for the movie: for the role of Odysseus' **galley** ship, Nolan enlisted the Draken. The Draken is not technically period-accurate for The Odyssey's Late Bronze Age setting, but neither is the movie's contemporary English dialogue, or its choice of Matt Damon as Odysseus.

Commissioned in 2010 by Norwegian oil and gas **magnate** Sigurd Aase, the Draken is built with overlapping oak planks based on ship descriptions in Viking **skaldic** poems. At 114 feet long and 26 feet wide, with a single 79-foot-tall mast, the ship is a scaled-up version of the famous Gokstad ship built around 890 CE. The Draken's **maiden voyage** took place in 2012, and a crew of 100 rowers successfully recreated the Vikings' **transatlantic** crossing from Norway to Newfoundland only four years later. Today, it routinely sails to ports around the world for exhibitions and educational tours.

Word Treasure

galley -- A galley is a long ship that is rowed with oars.
magnate -- A magnate is a very rich and powerful person in business.
skaldic -- Skaldic means the old poems written by Viking poets.
maiden voyage -- A maiden voyage is the first trip a ship ever makes.
transatlantic -- Transatlantic means crossing the Atlantic Ocean from one side to the other.

Background you need

The Draken Harald Hårfagre is a large wooden Viking-style ship built with overlapping oak planks, based on descriptions in old Viking poems.

It was used in Christopher Nolan's film The Odyssey as the ship of Odysseus, because the director preferred full-sized real sets over computer-made images.

The ship is kept going by a professional crew and volunteers, and it now needs routine maintenance, so its owners are asking for volunteers who can travel to Norway.

When it is not filming, the Draken sails to ports around the world for exhibitions and educational tours, letting people see a Viking-style ship up close.

Break it down

LEAD: The lifesize wooden ship used as Odysseus' galley in Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey needs routine maintenance, and its owners are asking for volunteers who can get to Norway by April 2027.

KEY EVENT: Volunteers are invited to apply online to help care for the Draken Harald Hårfagre.

+- WHO: The ship's owners and the community that keeps the project moving, plus the volunteers they hope to recruit.

+- WHEN: The maintenance is scheduled ahead of April 2027, when volunteers need to be able to reach Norway.

EVIDENCE: The Draken is a 50-oar, 114-foot-long ship with a 79-foot-tall mast, built with overlapping oak planks after ship descriptions in Viking skaldic poems; its crew of 100 rowers recreated the Vikings' transatlantic crossing from Norway to Newfoundland in 2016.

OPEN QUESTION: Will enough volunteers sign up in time to help with the ship's maintenance?

Why it matters

The Draken is a working piece of living history that teaches people about Viking seafaring, and keeping it sailing shows how real ships and practical effects can bring a story to life better than computer imagery alone.

Test what you remember

1. What is the Draken Harald Hårfagre scheduled for?

- (A) Routine maintenance
- (B) Being broken up for timber
- (C) A permanent museum display in Oslo
- (D) A race across the Atlantic

2. How many oars does the Draken have?

- (A) 100
- (B) 26
- (C) 50
- (D) 79

3. What role did the Draken play in Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey?

- (A) It was a computer-generated model
- (B) It was Odysseus' galley ship
- (C) It carried the film cameras
- (D) It was built as the Trojan Horse

4. Who commissioned the Draken, and in what year?

- (A) Matt Damon in 2016
- (B) The Gokstad museum in 890 CE
- (C) Christopher Nolan in 2012
- (D) Sigurd Aase in 2010

5. How big is the Draken?

- (A) 50 feet long with a single 26-foot mast
- (B) 26 feet long with 114 oars
- (C) 79 feet long and 114 feet wide
- (D) 114 feet long and 26 feet wide, with a 79-foot-tall mast

6. In which year did a crew of 100 rowers recreate the Vikings' transatlantic crossing in the Draken?

- (A) 2016
- (B) 2012
- (C) 890 CE
- (D) 2010

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The Draken's official website: Volunteering offers a hands-on way to contribute while learning about the vessel and the community that keeps the project moving.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):